

**LIFE-SIZED** Flex board cutouts of Rahul and state Congress leaders in Mandya

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



**"WHAT'S THE HARM EVEN IF IT IS A BRANDING EXERCISE? RAHUL IS OUR BEST-KNOWN LEADER AND PEOPLE ARE CONNECTING WITH THE CONGRESS..."**

**DIGVIJAYA SINGH**
*Rajya Sabha MP, BJY committee head*



**"INDIA IS GOING THROUGH A CONSTITUTIONAL CRISIS. I'M WITH ANYONE WHO TALKS OF UNITING INDIA INSTEAD OF SPREADING HATRED..."**

**YOGENDRA YADAV**
*Political activist, Swaraj India*

a family of doctors, Dr Hedna, 48, shares a container with 11 others, wakes up at 4.30 every morning so he has enough time to use the common toilet before getting ready for the walk. "When the country is in distress, personal comforts are meaningless. We are banking on the Congress to end the BJP's misgovernance. But if it strays after coming to power, we will raise our voice against it too. The yatra is not about the Congress, but about India and its values," says Hedna, as he finishes a simple vegetarian lunch along with a hundred others in a makeshift dining hall.

Those are the sentiments that led activist-turned-politician Yogendra Yadav to join the BJY. Or 80-year-old former Bombay High Court judge Baban G. Kolse Patil. In the run-up to the 2019 general election, Yadav had famously said the Congress should be shut down; today, he claims he has not seen a more honest leader than Rahul. He attributes the change of heart to the Congress 'waking up' to its responsibility of challenging the BJP on the streets. "India is going through an unprecedented constitutional crisis. I'm with anyone who talks of uniting India," says Yadav, who founded the political party Swaraj India. He is happy walking at the rear end of the walkathon, with the likes of former JNU students' union leader Kanhaiya Kumar, a new party recruit.

Up front, Rahul is both the brand ambassador for BJY and its brand. From the beginning, the yatra, planned by a panel headed by Rajya Sabha MP Digvijaya Singh, projected Rahul as its face, though he doesn't hold any official position in the party. Sonia made a brief appearance for 30 minutes; Priyanka Gandhi is yet to show up. "What's the harm even if it is a branding exercise for Rahul? He is our best-known leader and people are connecting with the Congress through him. That's what we want," says Digvijaya, who at 75, has been walking the full length every day, leading a small Seva Dal advance guard. That initial objective has been achieved. People and political observers have taken note of this six-month-long public commitment of Rahul, known for his regular vanishing acts. Besides supporters bussed down to join the walk daily, locals are paying attention to his words. But these are initial days, and only two southern states—where the party anyway has a strong base—have been properly crossed. Has the Congress avoided an instant assessment of the BJY by staying away from Gujarat and Himachal? Perhaps, but Rahul doesn't seem focused on immediate outcomes. "I am by nature a believer in *tapasya*," he tweeted as the BJY completed a month. As that mobile penance continues, the next Congress chief will have to find a way to channelise the momentum derived from the yatra into electoral dividend. Otherwise, it will remain what a Karnataka youngster described it as—entertainment and free food. Also, there may not be another opportunity to save Rahul. ■